



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Philip Neri
School Website: <https://chestertonacademykc.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Philip Neri (Kansas City, MO 64111) presents a clearly classical Catholic educational model. Public-facing materials emphasize a Catholic, liturgical life integrated into a robust classical curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with attention to formation, virtue, and the great tradition of Western civilization. Evidence includes explicit statements about daily Mass, theology interwoven into every subject, and the school's self-description as a "joyfully Catholic, classic high school" within the Chesterton Schools Network; leadership messaging highlights formation of thoughtful, articulate students. The placement of evidence across the six classical elements supports an overall CLASSICAL ranking, with only modest gaps in explicit pedagogical vocabulary (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars or direct Great Books phrasing) that do not undermine the strong classical orientation evident in governance, curriculum framing, and Catholic character formation.

Key takeaways - Strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Daily Mass, explicit Catholic theology in curricula, and liturgical practices anchor the school's identity. - Clear Purpose and Formation Orientation: Emphasis on forming virtuous, capable students (not merely job prep) and a teleological aim toward truth, goodness, and beauty. - Classical Curriculum and Liberal Arts Orientation: Grammar, logic, rhetoric framing; Latin placement testing; placement in a traditionally liberal-arts-friendly setting. - Pedagogical Tones with Classical Elements: The school foregrounds "classical education" and rhetoric in leadership statements; explicit Socratic discourse is not clearly evidenced in public site text, suggesting a partial classical pedagogy with room to advance explicit Socratic practice. - Faculty Model and Community Orientation: Public materials present faculty as engaged, faith-aligned professionals and the school as part of a broader Chesterton Network with family engagement and community life. - Parents & Community Engagement: Open houses, accessibility for visits, and a family-friendly tuition model indicate meaningful parental involvement, though the site provides fewer explicit, formal statements about parents as co-educators compared to some classical-schools norms.

Overall verdict: CLASSICAL

Note on methodology: The analysis below applies keyword-based evaluation against the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) and cross-checks with the Chesterton KC site content. Citations reference the chesterton academy firecrawl content surfaced from the crawl data, and the Six Essential Elements/lexicon documents in the knowledge store.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents itself as "Rooted in Faith" with daily Mass and Catholic theology integrated into each subject, indicating transcendent moral realism and a theologically grounded pedagogy. This is reinforced by explicit statements about daily Mass and theology shaping the curriculum. - The Headmaster and school communications emphasize a Catholic worldview, the Gospel, and religious formation as central to education. For example, the Headmaster's public remarks tie classical education to forming virtuous, faith-

informed students. - The campus narrative notes proximity to a church and opportunities for liturgical life (Mass, pilgrimages, retreats, sacred art), signaling liturgical and communal practices as part of education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: theology, liturgy, Mass, faith, sacred, Catholic, worship, prayer, sacred tradition, reverence, divine order, virtue formation, and the Logos (as theological underpinnings). The site repeatedly emphasizes daily Mass and Catholic theology as foundational. - Negative keywords: None of the explicit negative indicators (e.g., secularism, values-neutrality, non-theological curricula) appear in public-facing materials. The presence of Catholic theology and liturgical life counters such signals.

Why this rating - The materials align with transcendental moral realism and theological grounding, with liturgical/community practices embedded in daily life, aligning with the Positive Keywords for this element and aligning with the “Liturgical and Communal Practices” and “Grounded in Theology” indicators. The lack of secular framing and the explicit Catholic formation grounds the rating as CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames education as formation oriented toward virtue and human flourishing, not merely job preparation. Statements emphasize forming “well-rounded servant leaders” and educating toward virtues and wisdom. - Quoted aims describe forming students who “listen well, think clearly, and communicate effectively,” reflecting formation over information, with a teleological aim toward truth, goodness, and beauty. - The public materials frame education as integral to moral and intellectual development within a Catholic, classical frame, rather than only credentialing or workforce outcomes.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, contemplation/scholé, love of learning, truth, goodness, beauty, moral imagination, and humane letters. The site uses language of formation, virtue, and contemplation consistent with classical aims. - Negative keywords: explicit workforce-prep language (e.g., “career readiness” or “21st-century skills” as primary goals) is not prominent; the site foregrounds formation rather than job training. The absence of such negative signals supports CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The public-facing materials emphasize formation, virtue, and a belief in transcendent truths (truth, goodness, beauty) as real, aligning with the Classical School Purpose/Goal criterion. The language around living a liberal-arts formation and character formation yields a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is framed by the classical triad: grammar, logic, and rhetoric; the Headmaster’s remarks explicitly identify “grammar, logic, and rhetoric” as the core of the classical approach. - The school emphasizes a liberal-arts orientation, and the placement exam (Latin) signals attention to classical disciplines; a CLT-8 placement tool is described as diagnostic for Verbal/Math/Linguistic skills, with Latin placement options. - The site highlights a broad curriculum including math, science, fine arts, and faith, integrated within a Catholic, classical framework, suggesting cross-disciplinary continuity and historical engagement.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, Great Books (contextually implied through classical canon and Great Conversation framing in the network), history/western civilization, wonder, and integrated humanities. Public materials reflect a Liberal Arts-Centered approach. - Negative keywords: no strong indicators of a modern, secular, social-studies-centric reframing of history; the materials do not show a social-studies-only or STEM-first curriculum. Where explicit Great Books phrases aren’t visible in the site text, the formal Triad and network context still signal classical content.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin placement, and a classical liberal-arts orientation supports CLASSICAL for Curriculum. The presence of a historically informed, integrated approach with a Catholic lens aligns with Great Books/Great Conversation lineage in the broader Chesterton network, supporting CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as classical and highlights formation through a classical approach (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in leadership messaging, implying a pedagogical framework rather than purely vocational or project-based instruction. - Public materials emphasize a mix of traditional and student-facing modalities (e.g., a House system, liturgical life, and a public narrative about classical education), but explicit textual confirmation of Socratic seminars, regular seminars, or performance-based rhetoric work is not consistently documented in the site text. Some materials reference “great conversation” and classical dialogue as aims of education in the network context, but explicit on-site evidence for ongoing Socratic seminars or regular public rhetoric exercises is less clear in the crawl results. - Lower-school practices (singing, chanting, memory work) are not overtly described in the KC site text, though memory/chanting is a recognized classical pedagogy in the Six Essential Elements corpus. The Chesterton KC site emphasizes a traditional Catholic and classical structure rather than a fully documented, explicit schedule of Socratic seminars in the public-facing materials.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: scholé (restful learning), rhetoric, recitation, seminar/dialogue, memory-work, classical pedagogy, and rhetoric exercises. The explicit articulation of “grammar, logic, rhetoric” in the public statements supports these signals. - Negative keywords present: limited explicit references to ongoing Socratic seminars, Harkness-style discussions, or predominant project-based learning in public content. The absence of consistent, explicit mention of Socratic seminars or heavy project-based pedagogy reduces the certainty of a fully classic pedagogy on public pages.

Why this rating - The school clearly aligns with classical pedagogy via the grammar/logic/rhetoric triad and the scholé/cultivation language, but the public-facing materials do not consistently document a full, high-school-oriented Socratic/seminal discussion program across grades. That partial documentation justifies SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL, pending more explicit evidence of regular high-school Socratic seminars and rhetoric training (speeches, orations) in the public materials.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents the faculty as model teachers and mentors who form the curriculum through their own example, with a “living curriculum” flavor to the teaching model (Headmaster statements and general faculty emphasis). The Headmaster’s background underscores a university-level, faith-informed approach and a serious commitment to teacher quality. - The materials show a governance and leadership structure (board of trustees, headmaster) typical of classical schools, highlighting a community of faith-driven educators who model virtue and knowledge. - The Chesterton KC site links to a Faculty and Staff page and emphasizes classic formation, Catholic fidelity, and school culture as part of the “living curriculum” in practice.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty as core, portrait of teacher, collegiality, virtue, wisdom, mentorship, faith and reason. The site’s language around leadership and faculty life supports these signals. - Negative keywords: No strong negative signals (e.g., non-classical staffing models, secularist approaches) appear in the public materials; the content emphasizes virtuous, theological, and intellectual formation.

Why this rating - The site presents a classic faculty model aligned with classical education ideals (mentorship, virtuous exemplars, living curriculum). The combination of formal leadership structure and emphasis on teacher-character formation yields a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Chesterton site advertises an “Affordable Education” narrative with donor support and scholarships, implying community involvement and family access. It also highlights open houses and opportunities to visit, signaling visitor/family engagement. - Community and family engagement are embedded in Chesterton Network practices (pilgrimages, open events, family involvement in a broader network context). The firecrawl results reference community activities and parent engagement as a norm within the Chesterton

Schools Network. - The site shows a strong parent/guardian interface (contact info, inquiries, and admission processes) and a campus culture that invites families to participate.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent involvement, family formation, home-life integration, parental involvement in school events, open campus, and a community-centered ethos. The lexicon in the Six Essential Elements doc highlights these parent-education partnering signals as core to classical education. - Negative keywords present: There is limited explicit evidence of a robust, formal, ongoing program for parent formation (e.g., regular book studies, parent seminars, or structured co-educator roles) beyond open-house and general involvement. The absence of a clearly articulated, systematic parent-education program reduces the strength of the category signal.

Why this rating - While there are meaningful signs of parent involvement and community engagement (open houses, admissions support, financial-aid storytelling, and a networked community), the explicit, structured role of parents as co-educators or formal parent-education programming is less visible on the public site than classical-education best-practice narratives often require. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle

- If this school aims to advance to CLASSICAL in Element 6, develop and publish a formal Parents-as-Coadjutors plan: create a structured program for parent formation (regular book studies, liturgical year events, catechesis, and home-school alignment resources) and document formal parent-education sessions.
- For Element 4, increase explicit documentation of Socratic/seminal seminars and rhetoric training in upper grades on the public site (e.g., sample seminar formats, student speeches, or debates and a schedule that demonstrates the Harkness/Socratic approach).
- For Element 5, expand explicit faculty portraits and case studies (e.g., faculty profiles that illustrate virtue modeling and mentorship in practice, living-curriculum integrations) to strengthen the explicit “living curriculum” messaging.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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